

Recommendation Report: Proposal for a
Campus Fishing Pond at Central Maine
Community College

Reid Maxim

CM Technical Writing

4/27/2026

Executive Summary

This report explores the feasibility of constructing a stocked fishing pond at Central Maine Community College. This project will help determine whether a campus pond would provide recreational, educational, and wellness benefits for students while also staying financially realistic. Research methods included student surveys, interviews, campus observation, cost research, and academic studies on outdoor recreation. Results of the surveys and interviews suggest a strong student interest; possible classroom use and academic studies show multiple wellness benefits. Based on my research and findings, this report recommends that CMCC should pursue a phased development to a small to medium sized campus fishing pond.

Introduction

Central Maine Community College has an opportunity to improve student life through the creation of a stocked fishing pond on campus. Colleges around the world have been investing in increasing numbers in outdoor recreation spaces to improve student satisfaction, retention, and wellness. A fishing pond would create a unique campus feature while also supporting educational programs such as the schools Conservation Law Enforcement, Business and environmental studies. This report will examine whether a pond project would be practical and beneficial for CMCC.

Background

Many college campuses provide recreational amenities like trails, fitness centers and outdoor gather spaces. A small but growing subset of these colleges offering some form of fishing pond or water-based outdoor recreation area. It is also noted that there has been an increase in competition fishing teams being created by colleges. This provides opportunities for team building and provides students with opportunities for academic scholarships for their success or skills in competition.

CMCC is located in Maine, which has a rich history in outdoor recreation and fishing. Because of this a campus pond may align well with student interests and local values while also providing an opportunity for students who may not have spent their whole lives in Maine a chance at exploring some of the natural wonder and history our state provides.

The campus currently contains walking trails and access to Lake Auburn from the shore.

Unfortunately, that section of the lake is closed to any form of recreation due to the drinking water intake plant that is directly next to the campus. After a survey of the campus, I have identified 3 possible locations for a small to medium pond to be constructed. This would provide access to water recreation and expand upon the current outdoor infrastructure the campus already provides.

Research Methods

Research for this report included several methods:

Student Survey

I created a google forms survey and asked CMCC students on campus or in class discord groups to fill it out. The survey included questions about student interest in a stocked fishing pond on campus, should the public have access, and should it be used for classes? Eighteen students responded, providing a small but useful sample of campus opinion.

Bates Student Survey.

I spent some time on Bates College campus exploring and walking around the pond they have on campus. I stopped and surveyed some students and asked what the pond on campus provides to them as students. Would they participate in fishing if the pond was

stocked and gear was available and a short statement about their experience with the pond on campus.

Local Resident Bus Survey

While riding the public bus to school I surveyed a bus riders and asked if there was an interest in visiting/ using a stocked pond on CMCC campus, would public bus access make it more likely to visit a fishing pond at CMCC and what would interest them the most about a community fishing pond.

Site Observation

I walked to the CMCC campus and identified three possible pond locations, parking access, trail access, and nearby infrastructure.

Secondary Research

I reviewed Academic articles regarding studies done on the benefits of outdoor recreation for college students. State of Maine .gov websites with permit and legal information on the requirements of starting and maintaining a stocked pond. I also browsed multiple websites on pond construction and landscaping to find out exactly what would be needed for equipment to run and maintain a pond and the general cost of construction and materials as well as upkeep and maintenance.

Decision Criteria

Criteria	Importance
Cost	Must be affordable
Student Interest	Should benefit students
Educational Use	Should support classes/curriculum
Wellness Impact	Should reduce stress for students and staff
Feasibility	Must fit on campus land

Options

Option 1: No Pond

CMCC would make no changes to the current campus layout and would continue relying on existing outdoor spaces such as walking trails and limited lake access.

Pros:

- No financial cost to the college
- No additional maintenance or staffing required

Cons:

- No improvement to student recreation opportunities
- Does not address lack of water-based activities on campus

- Missed opportunity to improve student engagement and campus appeal

Option 2: Basic Pond

This option would involve constructing a small-to-medium sized stocked pond with basic features such as fish stocking, seating areas, and integration with existing campus walking trails.

Pros:

- Lower cost compared to larger projects.
- Provides immediate recreational and relaxation benefits for students.
- Easier to maintain and manage than larger scale pond projects.
- Could be used for educational purposes immediately with the setup and managing of the pond and stocked wildlife

Cons:

- Limited features compared to a full recreation space
- May not support large-scale campus events or programs

Option 3: Full Size Recreation Pond

Construct a larger pond with fishing dock, lighting, landscaped surroundings with seating, and designated classroom areas for classroom use or events.

Pros:

- Maximizes recreational, educational, and social benefits
- Could support classes, events, and potential fishing programs/competitive fishing team
- Strong potential to attract prospective students

Cons:

- significantly higher cost
- Longer construction timeline
- Increased maintenance and operational complexity

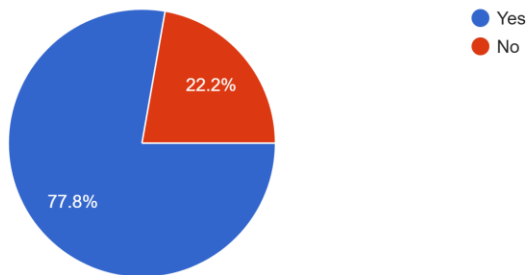
Analysis and Evaluation

The three proposed options were evaluated using the criteria of cost, student interest, educational value, wellness impact, feasibility, and maintenance requirements. Data collected from surveys, interviews, site observations, and secondary research were used to compare each option.

Student Interest

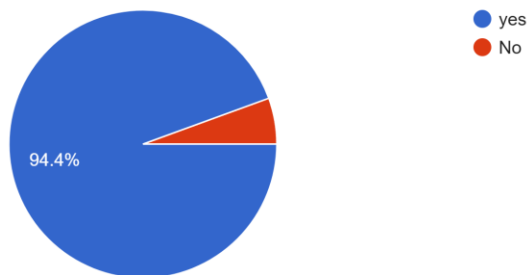
Results from student surveys indicate a strong interest in a campus fishing pond. 77% of students surveyed responded that they would utilize a stocked fishing pond on campus. (Maxim, 2026)

Would you use a stocked fishing pond on campus?
18 responses



94.4% of responders of the survey said they believed there would be a benefit to use of the pond in classes/school curriculum. (Maxim, 2026)

Should CMCC use the pond for classes? (Conservation Law Enforcement or any class that could use the pond to learn)
18 responses



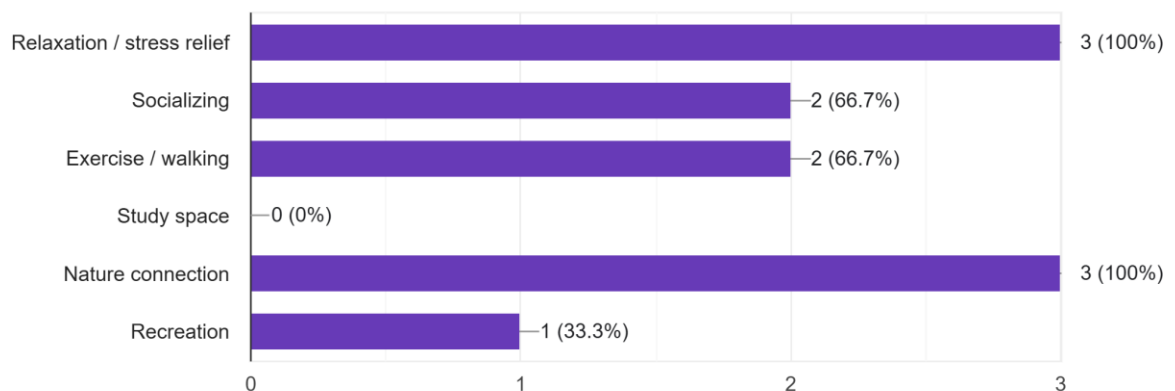
Bates College Student Interview

Interviewing students on a college campus with a pond, brought good insight into some of the possible benefits to mental health and wellness for students with access to a pond. students surveyed on possible benefits of a pond on campus and what they feel or use it for.

100% of surveyed students said the pond provided stress relief / relaxation as well as a place to connect with nature. 66.7% reported socializing as well as exercising / walking as a benefit. (Maxim, 2026)

What benefits do you think the pond area provides for students? (Select all that apply)

3 responses



When asked to briefly describe how the pond area impacts your college experience:

“I get to see a lot of different birds, the koi fish are funny and I like that the community uses it as a place to walk and get exercise.” and “its a nice place to relax and meet with friends on a nice day. enjoy reading in a chair by the pond when its warm. ice skating on the pond in winter is fun.” (Maxim, 2026)

I think the positive reviews from students who actively get to interact with a pond on their campus and survey responses help support and build a base of what a pond at CMCC would look like and how it would impact students on campus and serve an educational role.

Educational Value

A campus fishing pond would provide educational benefits on top of a space for recreation. Survey responses show student interest and support in the idea of using the pond for academic purposes.

Research supports this type of use. According to the peer reviewed article Benefits of Campus Outdoor Recreation Programs, recreation spaces provide opportunities to “support academic programs directly” The authors writes "For colleges and universities, these benefits include positive effects on student recruitment, retention, and satisfaction and the opportunity for recreation programs to support academic programs directly."

Some of the key points she brings up in the paper is the correlation between outdoor academic programs and increased academic success, “participation correlates with better grades, persistence, and overall performance.”

Because of these factors, the basic pond and full recreation pond options offer a clear education advantages vs the no pond option that provides none.

Wellness and Student Experience

A campus fishing pond would provide wellness benefits and improve the overall student experience. Survey responses and student feedback suggest that many students are interested in having a quiet outdoor space to relax and socialize or take a break between classes.

Research strongly supports the connection between outdoor recreation and mental health. According to the peer reviewed article about Benefits of Campus Outdoor Recreation Programs, participation in outdoor activities is associated with “lower levels of stress and anxiety” as well as improved mental and physical health. The authors also note that students involved in recreation experience “better and more numerous social connections.” (Benefits of campus outdoor recreation programs,2017)

This means a campus pond could serve as more than just a recreational feature. It would provide a space where students can reduce stress, build friendships, and feel more connected to campus life. This could be especially beneficial for CMCC where many students commute and may not spend time on campus outside of classes.

Because of these factors, both pond options provide clear wellness and student experience benefits, while the no pond option does not improve current conditions.

Cost and Feasibility

Cost is one of the most important factors when evaluating whether a campus pond is a realistic project. Research on [homeguide.com](https://www.homeguide.com) and multiple landscaping business shows that building a small to medium sized pond would require an estimated investment between \$30,000 and \$60,000 depending on size, soil conditions, drainage and additional features.

In addition to construction costs, several key components are required to maintain a functioning pond. Things like pump systems to circulate water can cost between \$350 - \$1500. Filtration systems that range from \$500-\$2000 to help filter debris and maintain water quality. Other components such as skimmers, lighting and decorative landscaping or seating can add additional costs depending on pond layout and design.

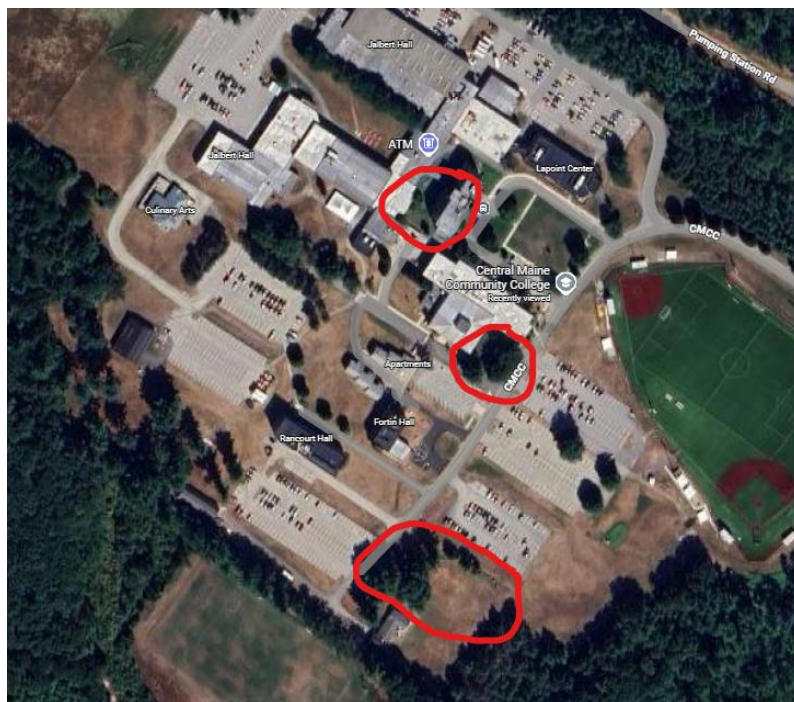
These costs show that while a pond is a large investment, it is still financially achievable with a phased approach to building. A smaller basic pond would require fewer materials and less upfront cost, making it a more realistic starting point.

A factor to consider is the ability to fundraise. The school for a small upfront cost could sponsor or host a fishing derby where all proceeds go to the construction of the pond.

Maine is also home to more than a few social media influencers whos niche is fishing. It would be possible to combine both of these options on top of traditional fundraising means to get a large portion of the capitol required to start the project.

Site observation also supports feasibility. Three potential pond locations were identified on campus, all of which have access to existing trails and are relatively close to parking and

infrastructure. This suggests that construction is physically possible without major disruption to the current campus layout.



Location 1) small pond area. Close to school building so construction could be difficult but would have the most access and would make for a very aesthetic location that could be in view from multiple indoor locations.



Location 2) slightly larger sized pond while remaining directly on campus. Located between the esports arena/gym facilities and student dorms.



Location 3) provides a large space allowing for any size pond to be built. Located above the sports fields and next to student parking it would allow for maximum access to the pond and the most construction space for addons for the pond like seating and designated classroom areas.



Because of these factors, a basic pond is more financially and logistically feasible than a full recreation pond, while still providing meaningful benefits.

Comparison of Options

When comparing the three options, clear differences can be seen based on cost, benefits and feasibility.

Option 1 involves making no changes, this option performs best in terms of cost and maintenance since it requires no investment. However, it does not provide any improvements to student experience, wellness and educational opportunities. It also does not address the current lack of water/outdoor recreation on campus.

Option 2 the basic pond provides the best balance between benefits and feasibility. It offers meaningful improvements to student wellness, recreation and educational use while keeping cost and maintenance at a manageable level. It also allows for future expansion through a phased development approach.

Option 3 the full recreation pond offers the greatest potential benefits. It could provide a wide range of recreational, educational and social opportunities. As well as serve as a strong attraction for prospective students. However, it also has the highest cost, longest construction timeline, and most demanding maintenance requirements, making it less practical as an initial project.

Recommendation

Based on the analysis of cost, student interest, educational value, wellness impact, feasibility and maintenance. This report recommends that Central Maine Community College pursues option 2: the construction of a basic campus fishing pond.

This option provides the strongest balance between benefits and practicality. Survey results indicate strong student interests in a campus pond and research supports the

educational and wellness advantages of outdoor recreation spaces. The basic pond option is financially manageable and requires less maintenance than a full recreation pond.

This option also allows for future expansion through a phased development approach, making it a flexible and long term investment for the college.

Implementation Plan

The development of a campus fishing pond could be completed through a phased approach to reduce financial risk and allow for gradual expansion.

Phase 1: Planning and Approval (1–3 months)

- Finalize pond location based on site observations
- Review environmental and state permit requirements
- Develop a detailed budget and project plan including fundraising and promotion.

Phase 2: Construction (2–4 months)

- Excavate pond area
- Install liner, drainage systems, and water circulation equipment
- Ensure proper safety measures are in place

Phase 3: Setup and Opening (1 month)

- Stock pond with fish

- Install seating, signage, and basic landscaping

- Open pond for student use

Phase 4: Future Expansion (optional)

- Add features such as docks, lighting, or expanded landscaping

- Integrate more classroom use or campus programming

This phased approach allows CMCC to begin with a functional and beneficial campus feature while maintaining flexibility for future improvements.

Conclusion

Central Maine Community College currently lacks accessible water based recreation despite its location and large outdoor area on campus. A fishing and recreating pond on campus would provide significant benefits including improved student wellness, increased opportunities for social connection and support for academic programs such as the schools conservation law program.

Research and survey data indicate a strong interest in a pond for outdoor recreation on campus. while cost analysis shows that a smaller, phased approach is financially realistic, while a full recreation pond offers additional benefits, a basic pond provides the best balance between impact and feasibility.

Based on these findings, CMCC should move forward with the planning and development of a campus fishing pond. This project shows a practical investment in the student experience, campus engagement and long term community value.

References

HomeGuide. (n.d.). *Cost to build a pond*. Retrieved May 2, 2026, from <https://homeguide.com/costs/cost-to-build-a-pond>

KS Land & Pond. (n.d.). *Pond construction price guide*. Retrieved May 2, 2026, from <https://www.kslandandpond.com/articles/pond-construction-price-guide/>

Outdoor recreation and college student wellbeing study. (2021). *ScienceDirect*.
<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S221307802100061X>

Benefits of campus outdoor recreation programs: A review of the literature. (2017).
ResearchGate.
https://www.researchgate.net/publication/312930150_Benefits_of_Campus_Outdoor_Recreation_Programs_A_Review_of_the_Literature

Maxim, R. (2026). *CMCC student survey on campus fishing pond interest* [Unpublished survey data].
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSeg3L-mnoP_wfrhibyfFH3ZUsahpAopu7ClH6E2BLuGcvVRLg/viewform?usp=sharing&oid=101636876410651886787

Maxim, R. (2026). *Bates College student interviews on campus pond use* [Unpublished interview data].
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSc3_u2F1shEvri-aaRUHaHMnMKCOOgCyo70umafSw1G1Kn1xQ/viewform?usp=sharing&oid=101636876410651886787

Maxim, R. (2026). *Local bus rider survey on community pond interest* [Unpublished survey data].

<https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSfNCvOA-Pylj-0xDPfOjZHvil-lw02GLbRF2zk44cSDu1VWVA/viewform?usp=sharing&ouid=101636876410651886787>

Maxim, R. (2026). *Site observation of Central Maine Community College campus* [Unpublished field notes].

<https://github.com/ReidMaxim/Techwritingfinal>